



Department of Economics
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Letter of Recommendation for Andy Daileanes

I have had the pleasure of knowing Andy since August of 2025 when he enrolled in Economics 229: Urban Economics. Andy is now enrolled in my sports economics class – Eco 329: Sports Economics – and I’ve had the opportunity to get to know him a bit better this semester. Andy has proven himself to be a very gifted student in both of my classes. He’s an excellent writer, he possesses outstanding economic intuition and problem solving skills, and he’s a very hard worker. Last semester, in my urban economics course, he was clearly the best student in a class of 34. And, in fact, he was one of the best students I’ve had in urban economics over the past decade. Andy would be an excellent addition to any work or graduate school environment. He is thoughtful and respectful in his interactions with others, he works well in teams, and his work ethic coupled with analytical and writing skills would allow him to excel at a wide variety of assignments. I think Andy would be particularly well suited to jobs involving data analytics.

Urban economics is a writing intensive, 200 level elective in the economics major. In the course, I require students to complete two different types of assignments. “Data analysis” assignments are short papers that require students to learn and master the use of the program Social Explorer. Social Explorer is a mapping program that presents census data in maps that can be tailored to the user’s needs. Andy and his partner consistently created maps and write-ups that were among the very best in the class. Not only was the quality of Andy’s work first-rate, when I met with his partner at the end of the semester (about something unrelated) her working relationship with Andy came up in conversation. She raved about easy it had been to work with Andy and how much she felt that they learned from having the opportunity to work with one another. As strong as Andy’s work was on the data analysis assignments, his work on the longer papers for the course – “The City

Research Project" (CRP) – was even better. For the CRP I ask students to write two papers about a single city of their choosing. The first paper asks student to explore and analyze the city's spatial structure, and the second paper asks students to do a transportation or industry case study. Andy earned the highest grade in the class on each paper, and – on the second paper – he earned the highest grade I've given on any paper in this course in the past ten years (98%). What made Andy's second paper particularly impressive was the way that he integrated the use of economic models from the course with the data he gathered and presented using Social Explorer. His paper examined the spatial competition between sports bars in Boston, and the maps and the analysis were simply superlative. There aren't many instances when I receive a student paper I would enjoy rereading, but I've genuinely enjoyed rereading Andy's paper in preparing to write this letter of recommendation.

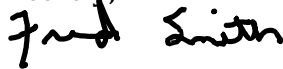
This semester Andy is taking sports economics with me. The work he has turned in so far has been excellent. The major assignment for the semester – an empirical paper on a subject of the student's choosing – is due in about a month. However, the work that Andy has submitted so far has me excited to read his paper. I won't be at all surprised if Andy's paper is one of the top two or three papers in the class. At a minimum, Andy's research question is *far* more sophisticated and advanced than the typical research question that students pose in this course. (Andy is looking at how the structure of the NBA salary cap (with non-linear penalties) affects teams' roster construction. The question makes outstanding use of microeconomic theory, and it will require that Andy build and estimate a rather sophisticated econometric model.)

Andy has been a terrific student throughout his tenure at Davidson, although I think it is worth noting that his GPA – while very strong – is a bit lower than I think it probably "should" be. He had one "off" semester during the spring of his sophomore year. He earned a B+ in our econometrics course (which is an *excellent* grade since the class average for this course is typically between a B- and C+). Econometrics is an enormous amount of work, though, and I suspect that the work that Andy put into that course may have affected his performance in his other economics course and his computer science course. I've had students who are far less talented than Andy earn an A or A- in computer science (CSC) 121, so his grade in that class is a poor reflection of what Andy is capable of. He's had no trouble whatsoever in generating the necessary code in R for my sports economics course.

Beyond his work in the classroom, Andy has been active playing club sports and volunteering for CatsStats (the sports analytics group at Davidson College). It is clear from my interactions with Andy that he is a very kind, thoughtful, and mature young man. I've observed his interactions with his peers in sports economics, and he's obviously well liked and gets along very well with his classmates. I've been encouraging Andy to talk more in class this semester, for he tends to be rather quiet. However, there is no question that Andy will be an invaluable member of any team that he is assigned to for group projects. Given his academic talents and kind, thoughtful personality, I think Andy has the potential to evolve into a leader who leads quietly through example.

Andy is a terrific young man, and I'd gladly hire him to be a research assistant if he weren't graduating. I am confident that his kindness and thoughtfulness coupled with his outstanding analytical and writing skills will make him a great addition to any work environment. If I can provide any additional support for Andy, then please contact me at your convenience.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Fred Smith". The signature is written in a cursive, slightly stylized font.

Fred H. Smith
Professor of Economics
Davidson College